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Editorial Style Summary

“I’ve learned that people will forget what you said, people will forget what you did, but people will never forget how you made them feel.”

Maya Angelou

Why a guide?

When people read about a product or encounter content while using it, they should always experience the same clear, supportive voice. Consistency builds confidence, strengthens the brand and makes healthcare easier to understand.

At Sutter Sync, we believe the style, tone and language of our communications matter. That's why we opened this guide with Maya Angelou's famous quote. We recognize that what and how we communicate has a direct impact on people's health and wellbeing.

Like any relationship, communication is the foundation of trust, connection, and belonging. Health is deeply personal. If we are truly committed to caring for our patients and helping them feel better, we must recognize that both how and what we communicate are fundamental to effective care.

Goal

To ensure patients feel confident, safe, and well connected

Let's take a look at how we achieve that...

Sutter Sync Editorial Style Summary

Resources

The design team takes pride in our iterative approach — this style guide is no exception. The key factor in any patient communication is listening. Sutter Sync content takes pains to listen and allow our language to evolve with the people we communicate with.

However, we never change everything over night. Think the Ship of Theseus (also called Theseus's Paradox) where a ship has all of its wooden boards replaced one at a time over many years.

Here are the resources that have informed our approach:

- [Sutter Health brand guidelines](#)
- Chandler, D. (2017). Semiotics The Basics, Routledge
- Halvarson, K. & Rach, M. (2012). Content Strategy for the Web, Second Edition. New Riders
- Metts, M.J. & Welfle, A. (2020). Writing is Designing. Rosenfield
- Podmajersky, T. (2019). Strategic Writing for UX. O'Reilly Media
- Richards, S. (2017). Content Design. Kemp House.

We could never create a rule for every little detail. Here's what's recommended for any rules not made explicit in this guide:

For punctuation, default to [AP Style book](#)

For inclusion, we reference to [GLAAD Media reference guide](#) and [Conscious style guide](#)

Note

For marketing we often default to Sutter Health's approach to style and grammar. When it comes to the product experience copy and our in-product education we are inclusive of the Sutter approach while maintaining service design and in-product experience best practices.

Voice summary

Based on Sutter Health's brand guidelines

- We get to the point quickly
- We're honest
- We're empathetic and center on the person

Show you care

- Acknowledge why it matters
- Elevate human interaction
- Write with respect and care
- Celebrate health, happiness, and wellness in every stage and variation

Do's and don'ts

We are

- Conversational
- Action-oriented
- Easy to understand
- Enthusiastic

We aren't

- Long-winded
- Rushed
- Sappy
- Assumptive

We do

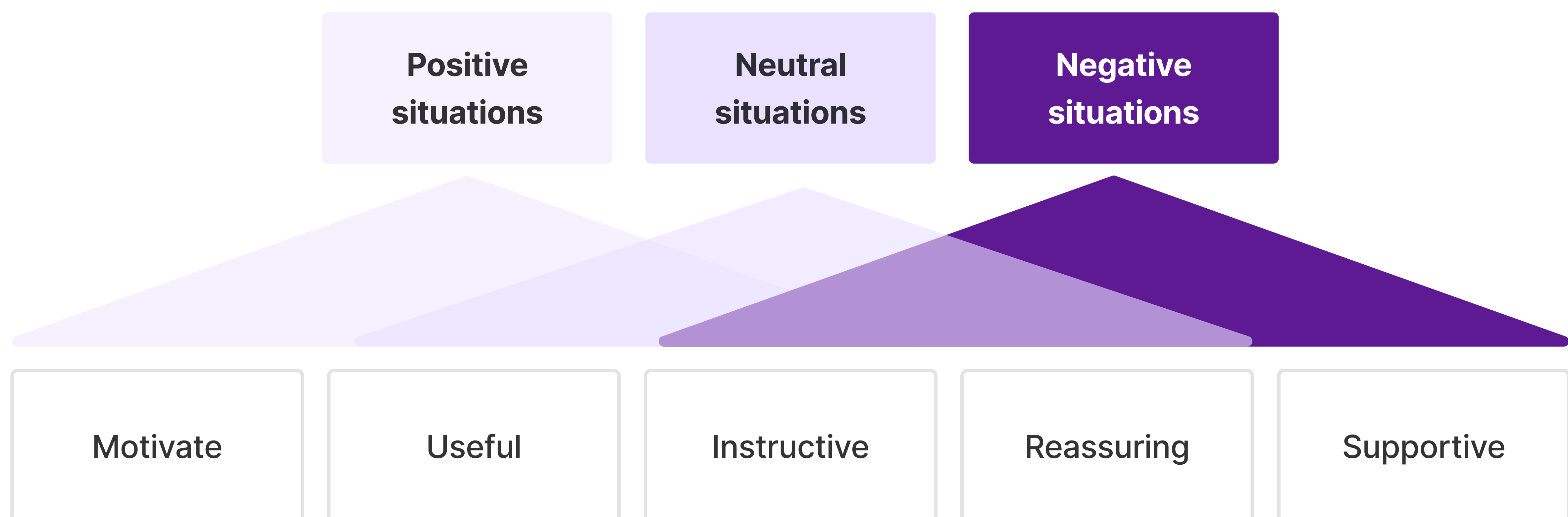
- Meet people where they are
- Lead with why
- Connect actions to outcomes
- Allow personality to show

We don't

- Use hyperbole
- Leave the reader behind

Tone summary

A tone map helps us step into our patient’s shoes, considering what they may be feeling, thinking, and needing in a specific moment. By grounding writing in context, it ensures our words are not only clear and consistent, but also appropriate for the situation. This creates communication that feels more empathetic, supportive, and effective for the people we’re trying to reach.



Please note the 3 tones per situation are only an emphasis based on the situation. We want to exercise every tone here in our writing, no matter the situation.

Remember, writing is a craft — explore it

Like our everyday language, feel free to “break a grammar rule” for tone’s sake. Particularly if we are attempting to make the copy feel human, conversational, and reassuring. Please be mindful and have a clear intent when you choose to “break” the rule, but consider this permission granted to explore new ways to reach a patient through the written word. We can always lean on our editorial process to review.

“Art is not a mirror held up to reality, but a hammer with which to shape it”

Bertolt Brecht

Sutter Sync’s content is not just a mirror that reflects health information. It's a tool that helps shape understanding, confidence, and action.

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User Experience (UX) Writing Guide

"User experience (UX) writing is the process of creating words in user experiences: The titles, buttons, labels, instructions, descriptions, notifications, warnings, and controls people see. It is also the set-up information, first-run experience, and how-to content that gives people the confidence to take the next step."

Torrey Podmajersky

Goals

It starts with storytelling

Skilled storytellers know their purpose and audience. This helps them to empathize and anticipate reactions and craft captivating words and images to create an experience for the audience. When a storyteller builds trust, audiences are willing to embark on the journey the storyteller creates.

Great, so how do we build trust?

Terrific question, we make it:

Concise

Keep it short and straightforward, we use people's time effectively.

Active

Folks are using this to get something done — help them by encouraging action.

Inclusive

Be plain and simple — accessible to every culture, creed, identity, capability, and lifestyle.

Consistent

Maintain a reliable tone and repeat words, like labels and names, when necessary.

Labels, forms and form fields

Every input needs a clear label

Take pains to consider which fields are necessary to the user and identify which fields are required and optional.

Keep forms short

If there is more than 5 input fields, group them logically, and give each group a page.

Form fields give the user active direction

It can also give an example of the input.

Sentence case headers

Use them across product and in education. Why? Because sentence case feels more natural and conversational, improves readability, and helps readers focus on the message rather than the formatting.

Accessibility

Every image needs an alt tag (alt=)

Even if there is no description. If there is no tag it will read the image file name. Describe what is in the image within the context of the user experience.

Yes:

No:

Every video needs closed captioning

Try to make the information in the video available in other formats as well.

Accessibility continued

Avoid images only

Images should be one of many forms of communication for various reasons to ensure comprehension.

Avoid giving obtuse direction

Users should rely on something specific rather than the ability to seek and find.

Yes: Select a language in your profile

No: Select from these options

Abbreviations

Use abbreviations only when readers can easily recognize them from context. Favor recognition over recall.

Why? Reading behavior depends heavily on the channel. Most people do not consume content in a linear, top-to-bottom, academic way. Instead, they scan, skim, jump between sections, or enter content midway through a page. In digital experiences, readers may scroll past an abbreviation's original definition or encounter a section in isolation. When this happens, they must recall what the abbreviation means, creating unnecessary effort. Whenever possible, use language that readers can recognize instantly rather than asking them to remember information from elsewhere.

Rule of thumb: If a reader could encounter the content without seeing the abbreviation's definition first, consider spelling it out.

UX writing style and tips

Human

To reduce friction (forcing users to stop and think) use universally accessible language.

Yes: Preparing video...

No: Buffering...

Concise and direct

There's limited time, and often limited space, to communicate with folks. Furthermore, the human eye tends to read every 3rd word, so omitting needless words is key to delivering information.

Yes: Save changes?

No: Would you like to save your changes?

First and second-person pronouns

Yes: We're working on your request

No: The system is processing the request

Active voice

Yes: We've sent a message to your email account.

No: A message has been sent to you email account.

Replace ambiguous terms with complete sentences

Yes: What kind of medicine would you like?

No: Medicine variant

UX writing style and tips continued

Apply symmetry

Yes: Upgrade to premium to get more space, search your notes, and collaborate with your team.

No: Upgrade to premium to get more room, functionality for message searching, and better team collaboration.

Emphasize outcomes

Yes: Get healthy lifestyle tips in your inbox

No: Join our newsletter

Keep it short

Reconsider the design if you cant write directions in under 8 words

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Education and Product to Patient Communication

"Self-belief does not necessarily ensure success, but self-disbelief assuredly spawns failure."

Albert Bandura

Goals

Be your favorite teacher

The best health education informs without intimidating, empowers without judging, and teaches with the warmth, personality, and clarity of the teacher you'll never forget. We encourage writing with a strong personality. Don't be afraid to make it — dare we say — a little fun.

Health literacy is foundational for self-efficacy

Giving folks a chance to feel empowered, comfortable, and safe should be the goal in everything we write. These general guidelines are the details we'll use in our writing to increase people's confidence and help them make confident choices about their health.

Communicating facts without shame

Shame occurs when someone is “othered” or made to feel flawed because of their behavior, beliefs, or personage. Our role is never to judge, but to inform and support. **Share facts plainly and without moral framing.** This allows us to uphold our responsibility to the patient — providing accurate guidance — while ensuring our tone preserves dignity and fosters trust.

Approach

Aim for 5th grade

- Use readability tools to assess the reading level of the content — here's a great tool: hemingwayapp.com
- Conduct user testing to make sure the material is effective

Use plain language

- Use everyday language and avoid medical jargon
- If technical terms are necessary, explain them in simple terms
- Keep sentences concise and straightforward
- Write in the active voice — it makes instructions clear and direct

Be clear and specific

- Provide specific instructions and actionable steps
- Use examples that are relatable to the audience's daily lives
- Be precise to prevent misunderstandings

Organize content logically

- Use clear headings and subheadings to organize content
- Use bullet points or numbered lists to break down complex information
- Divide information into small, manageable sections

Use images to clarify text

- Ensure graphics are easy to understand and culturally appropriate
- Include captions and labels for all visuals
- Include Alt text for screen readers

Use a conversational tone

- Include questions, checklists, and interactive elements
- Incorporate stories or testimonials to make content relatable

Approach continued

Use language inclusive of every group and culture

- Use examples, images, and scenarios culturally relevant and sensitive

Provide multiple formats like print, digital, and audio

- Offer translations commonly spoken by the audience
- Make sure content is compatible with read-aloud and screen readers

Writing about people

Why care about how we describe folks?

- Inclusive language is how patients feel seen, heard, and valued — ultimately getting them involved in their own healthcare.
- Inclusive writing also helps people understand and stick to their treatment plans, leading to better health outcomes.
- By recognizing and respecting cultural differences, healthcare providers can build trust and rapport, which are wildly important for effective patient-provider relationships

Age

Avoid all age related descriptions like “young”, “old” or “elderly”

Disabilities

When communicating directly about a disability take pains to use the appropriate term. When writing about a person with a disability, use respectful and person-first language, such as "person with a disability". Avoid idioms that reference disabilities like “Dumb down”, “turn a blind eye”, or “lame.”

Writing about people continued

Physical and cognitive medical conditions

Like disabilities, avoid idioms that reference medical conditions unless speaking directly to the condition. Never refer to the condition unless it's warranted. If it is, use respectful person-first language.

Gender and sex

Gender and sex are different. Sex is distinct from gender, and though categorized as male female, it refers to a person's biological attributes. Gender references social roles, behaviors, and expressions.

Spotlighting

Avoid describing groups as “guys” or “girls” and avoid any term that spotlights a gender or group.

Yes: Police officer

No: Policeman

We also don't want to preface with distinct identifications unless it is specifically relevant.

Yes: Marriage

No: Same-sex marriage

Heritage, nationality, and race

If culture or ethnicity occurs in the writing, we capitalize the name. If we're discussing skin color, the description is lowercase. Don't use hyphens when referring to dual heritage.

Some of special-to-sync terms

Proper Nouns: Brand Identity & Differentiators

These terms are unique parts of the Sutter Sync experience and should be treated as proper nouns, meaning they are always capitalized exactly as written.

Sutter Sync Pharmacist

Refers to a pharmacist who is part of the Sutter Sync program. Capitalize all words.

Sutter Sync Care Team

Refers to the multidisciplinary team supporting a patient's care through Sutter Sync. Capitalize both words when referring to the Sutter Sync care model.

Welcome Call

Refers to the introductory call that helps patients get started in the program. Capitalize both words.

Health Guides

Refers to Sutter Sync's educational resources and patient learning materials. Capitalize both words.

Sutter Sync Care Kit

Refers to the package of tools, devices, and resources provided to support participation in the program. Capitalize both words.

Why it matters: Consistent capitalization reinforces our brand, helps patients recognize key program elements, and differentiates the Sutter Sync experience from generic healthcare services.

Sentence case headers

Use them across product and in education. Why? Because sentence case feels more natural and conversational, improves readability, and helps readers focus on the message rather than the formatting.



“You still shall live, such virtue hath my pen.”
William Shakespeare, Sonnet 81